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Glossary

8 Glossary

This Glossary contains terms that are technical from an exegetical or linguistic viewpoint. Other terms not defined here may be found in a Bible dictionary.

ADVERB is a word that limits, describes, or qualifies a verb, an adjective, or another adverb. In English "quickly," "soon," "primarily," and "very" are adverbs.

AMBIGUITY refers to words or sentences that have more than one possible meaning in a given context. For example, in the sentence "Mike said that if Joe comes, he will speak to the president," "he" could refer to Mike or to Joe. Thus this sentence is **AMBIGUOUS**. Often what is ambiguous in written form is not ambiguous when actually spoken, since intonation and other features of speech help to make the meaning clear. In written discourse, context also helps to indicate which meaning is intended by the author.

APHRODISIAC refers to substances, often plants or parts of plants that are believed to enhance sexual desire.

APOCALYPTIC refers to a prophetic revelation concerning the end of the temporal world; for example, the book of Revelation is an apocalyptic writing.

The **APOCRYPHA** is a group of books included in the Greek **SEPTUAGINT** and the Old Testament of the Latin **VULGATE** but not in the **PROTOCANON** of the Hebrew canon. See also **DEUTEROCANON**.

ARAMAIC is a **SEMITIC** language that was widely used in Southwest Asia in lands east of the Mediterranean Sea before and during the time of Christ. It is related to **HEBREW** and in many contexts had replaced Hebrew in use among the Jewish people in the land of Israel at the time of the New Testament.

ARCHEOLOGY (ARCHAEOLOGICAL) refers to the study from materials from the past that are dug up or that are found and interpreted to explain life in earlier times. This evidence may lend support to written documents or may give us information to help us understand the text as well as the people of the days when the text was written.

AROMATIC refers to the leaves or resin of certain trees that produces a pleasing smell, such as mint, marjoram, or eucalyptus.

ARTICLE is a grammatical class of words, often obligatory, which indicate whether the word to which it is connected is definite or indefinite. In English the **DEFINITE ARTICLE** is "the," and the indefinite article is "a" or "an."

BORROWING is the process of using a foreign word in another language. For example, "matador" is a Spanish word that has been **BORROWED** by English speakers for "bullfighter."

CALYX is the outside part of a flower, usually green in color, which forms a cup-like structure into which the petals and other parts of the flower fit. In the pomegranate, the petals drop, leaving the calyx as part of the fruit.

CHIASMUS, or **CHIASTIC STRUCTURE** is a reversal of words or phrases in the second part of an otherwise parallel construction; for example:

A I

B was shapen

C in iniquity

C' in sin

B' did my mother conceive

A' me.

CLASSIFIER is a term used with another term (often a proper noun) to indicate to what category the latter belongs. "Town" may serve as a classifier in the phrase "town of Bethlehem," and "river" as a classifier in "river Jordan."

CLAUSE is a grammatical construction, normally consisting of a subject and a predicate.

COMMON LANGUAGE VERSION uses language that is widely understood and accepted by most speakers. In such a translation, substandard speech, dialect peculiarities, and highly literary or technical terms are avoided.

CONIFERS are trees such as pine, fir, cypress, and cedar that produce seeds inside of a hard, cone-shaped structure.

CONNOTATION involves the emotional attitude of a speaker (or writer) to an expression he uses, and the emotional response of the hearers (or readers). Connotations may be good or bad, strong or weak, and they are often described in such terms as "colloquial," "taboo," "vulgar," "old-fashioned," and "intimate."

CONSONANTS are speech sounds that are produced by blocking or restricting the passage of air as it comes from the lungs through the mouth. The written letters representing those sounds are also called consonants; for example, "b," "d," "f," "k," or "m" in English. Consonants were originally the only spoken sounds written in the Hebrew alphabet. Marks for **VOWELS** were added later above or below the consonants. See also **VOWELS**.

CONTEXT is that which precedes and/or follows any part of a discourse. For example, the context of a word or phrase in Scripture would be the words and phrases associated with it in the sentence, paragraph, section, and even the entire book in which it occurs. The context of a term often affects its meaning, so that a word does not mean exactly the same thing in one context that it does in another.

CULTURAL EQUIVALENT is a kind of translation in which certain details from the culture of the source language are changed because they have no meaning or may even carry a wrong meaning for speakers of the receptor language. Cultural equivalent translation should be used only when absolutely necessary for conveying the intended meaning, and it may be important to add an explanatory note. See **CULTURE**.

CULTURE (CULTURAL) is the combination of beliefs, values, social institutions, customs, and material objects (such as tools or ornaments) of any group of people. A culture is passed on from one generation to another but undergoes development or gradual change.

DECIDUOUS refers to trees like oaks that drop their leaves during a cold or dry season of the year and produce a new set in the following year. They stand in contrast to "evergreen" trees, which replace leaves as they die continuously throughout the year.

DEFINITE ARTICLE. See **ARTICLE**.

DESCRIPTIVE is said of a word or phrase that characterizes or describes another term.

DEUTEROCANON (DEUTEROCANONICAL) is another term for what is referred to by some as the **APOCRYPHA**. These are writings that are included in the Greek **SEPTUAGINT** and the Old Testament of the Latin **VULGATE** but not in the **PROTOCANON** of the Hebrew canon.

DOMESTICATE (DOMESTICATION), in translation, means to express a foreign word or concept in a way that makes it more like the receptor culture. For example, using "feet" and "inches" in expressing the measurements of Noah's ark or Solomon's Temple, rather than cubits, is "domestication." See **FOREIGNIZE**.

DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION refers to a translation that tries to give the intended meaning of the source text in a natural and meaningful way so that it produces a response in today's reader that is essentially equivalent to that of the original reader. **LITERAL** translations pay more attention to reproducing the forms found in the source text. For example, RSV follows the Hebrew wording of PSA 104:29 and says: "they die and return to their dust." CEV tries to give a dynamic equivalent translation: "they die and rot."

EMENDATION (EMEND) is a correction of a text. It is usually a change made by a scholar through a process of critical editing and not based directly on manuscript evidence.

EMPHASIZE means to give relative importance to an element in a discourse. Emphasis is conveyed by many different devices, depending on the language; for example, positioning of words, emphatic particles, intensifiers, or ideophones. In "Oh, that you had heeded my commandments!" (ISA 48:18, NKJV), the particle "Oh" marks this statement as emphatic.

EQUIVALENCE (EQUIVALENT) is a very close similarity in meaning or in form. See **DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION** and **FORMAL TRANSLATION**.

ETYMOLOGY is the study of the derivation or history of words. While this can be a helpful study in many ways, it is much more important to know how a word is understood by its users in the actual context of the source language.

EXEGESIS (EXEGETICAL) is the process of determining the meaning of a text (or the result of this process), normally in terms of "who said what to whom under what circumstances and with what intent." A correct exegesis is indispensable before a passage can be translated correctly.

EXPLICIT refers to meaning that is expressed overtly in the words of a discourse. This is in contrast to **IMPLICIT** information.

FAMILY in botany is a subdivision of an order in the classification of plants or trees. A family usually consists of several **GENERA**.

FIGURATIVE expression involves the use of words in other than their **LITERAL** or ordinary sense, in order to bring out some aspect of meaning by comparison or association. For example, when the psalmist says "my cup overflows," he is not saying his cup is too full. He is rather using a figure of speech to say that he is as content as someone who has been served a generous portion. **METAPHORS** and **SIMILES** are common figures of speech.

FOREIGNIZE (FOREIGNIZATION) refers to a general translation strategy that allows cultural items such as measurements, plants, animals, and technology to remain "foreign" to the reader instead of "domesticating" them by substituting cultural equivalents in the receptor language. When a translator converts "cubits" to "meters," "wolf" to "hyena," or "oak" to "iroko," he or she is "domesticating" the text. Leaving "cubits," "wolf," or "oak" in a translation in West Africa is foreignizing the text. See **DOMESTICATE**.

FORMAL TRANSLATION is a type of translation in which many features of the source text, especially the form of the discourse, have been literally reproduced in the translation. This approach often results in an unnatural style in the receptor language, or sometimes in the lack of any meaning at all. See **LITERAL**.

FUNCTIONAL EQUIVALENCE is a type of translation that attempts to convey the same set of communicative functions as that of the original source text. Some important functions of communication are to convey information, to express or evoke emotions, to promote changes in thinking or behavior, or to maintain good interpersonal relations. See also **DYNAMIC EQUIVALENT TRANSLATION**, which has a similar meaning.

GENERAL or **GENERIC**, refers to a general class or kind of object. It contrasts with PARTICULAR and SPECIFIC. For example, the word "food" is a generic term, while "fruit" is more specific. However, the word "fruit" is a generic term for the more specific word "orange."

GENUS (plural **GENERA**) is the usual major subdivision of a **FAMILY** or subfamily in the classification of organisms. A genus usually consists of more than one species.

GLOSSARY is a list, usually included at the back of a book, explaining or defining unusual words or expressions used in the text.

GRAMMAR refers to the rules governing the formation and arrangement of elements of meaning, words, and larger constructions in a language. If a sentence is grammatical, it follows the rules of normal speech, and sounds correct to a speaker of that language.

GREEK is the language in which the New Testament was written. It belongs to the Indo-European family of languages and was spoken in the area that is today called Greece. By the time of Christ, Greek was used by many of the people living in the eastern part of the Roman Empire, so that early Christians could speak and write to one another in Greek, even though they were born in different countries. By that time the entire Hebrew Old Testament had been translated into Greek, a version referred to as the **SEPTUAGINT**.

HEBREW is the language in which the Old Testament was written. It belongs to the **SEMITIC** family of languages. By the time of Christ, many Jewish people no longer used Hebrew as their common language, but spoke **ARAMAIC** (a language related to Hebrew) or **GREEK**.

IMPLICIT, or **IMPLIED**, refers to information that is conveyed by a text, but that is not expressed in words. The speaker assumes that the hearer understands the meaning. Often the meaning is clear from the **CONTEXT**. For example, when Hannah says in 1SA 2:6 “He brings down to Sheol and raises up,” the implied or implicit meaning is “raises up to life.” See **EXPLICIT**.

INTERPRETATION is the process of determining the meaning of a text (or the result of this process), normally in terms of “who said what to whom under what circumstances and with what intent.” A correct interpretation is indispensable before a passage can be translated correctly.

LINGUISTIC refers to language, especially the formal structure of language.

LITERAL means the ordinary or primary meaning of a term or expression, in contrast with a **FIGURATIVE** meaning. A literal translation is one that is very close to the forms and word order of the source language; such a translation is frequently unnatural or awkward in the **RECEPTOR LANGUAGE**.

LOAN WORD is a foreign word that is used in another language, resulting from the process of **BORROWING**. For example, “matador” is a Spanish word that has been **BORROWED** by English speakers for “bullfighter.”.

MANUSCRIPTS are books, documents, or letters written or copied by hand. Thousands of manuscript copies of various Old and New Testament books still exist, but none of the original manuscripts.

MASORETIC TEXT is the form of the text of the Hebrew Old Testament established by Hebrew scholars around the eighth and ninth centuries A.D.

MASTIC is the gum, resin, or sap that is produced by a tree when the inner bark is cut, particularly the gum from the lentisk or pistachio tree, which when it dries in lumps, it is valuable for incense.

METAPHOR is likening one object, event, or state (the “topic”) to another (the “image”) to which it is not directly or closely related in meaning. For example, when a person says “I am a worm,” he is describing his state as being lowly, miserable, or of no value. Biblical metaphors are often difficult to understand because the basis for the comparison is not always stated, as in the line “The LORD is my rock” (PSA 18:2). At other times either the image or the basis of comparison is unfamiliar or used differently in the receptor language. For example, when the psalmist says “He remembers that we are dust” (PSA 103:14), he is not referring to the dirt or dust on our bodies. Metaphors are the most commonly used figures of speech and are often so subtle that a speaker or writer is not conscious of the fact that he or she is using figurative language. See **SIMILE**.

METONYM (METONYMIC) is a figure of speech in which a part of an object is used to indicate the entire object (for example, “one hundred head” means “one hundred cows”), or in which an object stands for another object to which it is related (for example, “the crown” can refer to the king or even the entire royal government).

MODIFY is to directly affect the meaning of another part of the sentence, as when an adjective modifies a noun or an adverb modifies a verb.

NEGEV refers to the desert area in the southern part of the Holy Land.

NONFIGURATIVE involves the use of words in their literal or ordinary sense. See **FIGURATIVE**.

NOUN is a word that names a person, place, thing, quality, action or idea.

OVATE refers to a leaf in the shape of an egg.

PARABLE is a short story designed to illustrate or teach some truth, religious principle, or moral lesson. Jesus often used parables to illustrate truths concerning the kingdom of God (for example, the parable of the mustard seed in MRK 4:30; MRK 4:31; MRK 4:32).

PARALLEL (PARALLELISM) generally refers to some similarity in the content and/or form of two parts of a construction; for example, “Hear this, all peoples! Give ear, all inhabitants of the world.” The structures that correspond to each other in the two statements are said to be parallel. **PARALLEL PASSAGES** are two or more portions of biblical text that resemble each other, often by using a series of words that are identical. For example, the Lord’s Prayer as recorded in MAT 6:9; MAT 6:10; MAT 6:11; MAT 6:12; MAT 6:13 has as its parallel LUK 11:2; LUK 11:3; LUK 11:4.

PARTICULAR is the opposite of **GENERAL**.

PASSAGE is the text of Scripture in a specific location. It is usually thought of as comprising more than one verse, but it can be a single verse or part of a verse.

PENTATEUCH refers to the first five books of the Bible, sometimes called "the Torah," "the Law," or "the Books of Moses."

PHRASE is a dependent grammatical construction of two or more words, but less than a complete clause or a sentence. A phrase is usually given a name according to its main word, such as that of a noun phrase, verb phrase, or prepositional phrase. For example, "a purple coat" is a noun phrase, "behind the house" is a prepositional phrase, and "carried a heavy load" is a verb phrase.

PINNATE refers to trees or plants that have leaflets arranged on both sides of a stem, sometimes opposite each other, sometimes alternating. Such leaflets are part of what is called a "compound" leaf such as you will find on a frankincense tree.

PLURAL refers to the form of a word that indicates more than one. See **SINGULAR**.

POETRY (POETIC) refers to a literary genre that differs from everyday speech and from **PROSE** because of its rhythmic and heightened style. Poets use special language to create a mood or image to be shared with the hearer or reader. Each language has special stylistic devices such as figurative language, word order variation, wordplay, repetition or rhyming that are especially frequent in poetry (compare JDG 4:0 and JDG 5:0). The boundary between beautiful, artistic prose and poetry is sometimes difficult to determine, but speakers of a language can usually distinguish poetry from ordinary speech. Poetry is usually written or spoken in measured or balanced lines, while prose is not.

PREFIX is a part of a word that cannot stand alone and that is positioned at the beginning of the word to which it belongs; for example, "im-possible" or "re-structure."

PROSE is the ordinary form of spoken or written language, without a special style and structure such as elaborate imagery, meter, and rhythm that are often characteristic of **POETRY**. However, literary prose may share some of the features of poetry, such as figures of speech, wordplay, repetition, or even parallelism.

PROTOCANON includes the Hebrew books of the Old Testament and all of the New Testament. These books are commonly accepted as canonical by both Protestants and Roman Catholics.

QUALIFY is to limit the meaning of a term by means of another term. For example, in "old man," the term "old" qualifies the term "man."

READ (READING) refers to the wording of a particular manuscript for a passage. Two manuscripts may have different wordings in the same passage, or two versions may have two different meanings. For example, in 1SA 1:24 the Hebrew text says "three bulls," but the Greek and Syriac versions say "a three-year-old bull." These are different readings. See also **TEXT**.

RECEPTOR is the person(s) receiving a message. The **RECEPTOR LANGUAGE** is the language into which a translation is made. For example, in a translation from Hebrew into German, Hebrew is the source language and German is the receptor language.

REDUNDANT describes anything that is entirely predictable from the context. For example, in "John, he did it," the pronoun "he" is redundant. A feature may be redundant and yet may be important to retain in certain languages, perhaps for stylistic or grammatical reasons.

RENDER means to translate or express in a language different from the original.

RENDERING is the manner in which a specific passage is translated from one language to another.

RESTRUCTURE is to rearrange the various components of a sentence or other unit of discourse in the translation process.

RHETORICAL refers to forms of speech that are employed to highlight or make more attractive some aspect of a discourse. A **RHETORICAL QUESTION**, for example, is not a request for information but is usually a way of making an emphatic statement.

ROOT refers to the smallest element of a word, from which other words may be derived. For example, “friend” is the root of “friendliness.” In Hebrew most roots are made up of three consonants, and many words are formed on the basis of this root. For example, the root b-r-k is the basis for the noun “blessing,” the adjective “blessed,” and the verb “to bless.”

SEMANTIC refers to meaning. Semantics is the study of the meaning of language forms. Semantic categories (or classes) group words according to their meaning (objects, events, abstracts, etc.) in contrast to grammatical categories (nouns, verbs, etc.) A **SEMANTIC DOMAIN** is a definable area of experience that is referred to by a set of words whose meanings are in some way related. For example, kinship terms constitute a semantic domain. Similarly, the color terms of a language may be said to form a semantic domain.

Semitic refers to a family of languages that includes **Hebrew**, **Aramaic**, and Arabic.

SENTENCE is a grammatical construction composed of one or more clauses and capable of standing alone..

SEPTUAGINT is a translation of the Hebrew Old Testament into Greek, begun some two hundred years before Christ. It is often abbreviated as LXX.

SIMILE (pronounced SIM-i-lee) is a figure of speech that describes one event or object (the “topic”) by comparing it to another event or object (the “image”). Similes always use words of comparison such as “like” or “as.” “Your lips [the topic] are like a scarlet thread [the image]” is a simile from SNG 4:3. Similes differ from **METAPHORS** in that metaphors do not mark the image with words that indicate comparison. See **METAPHOR**.

SINGULAR refers to the form of a word that indicates one thing or person, in contrast to PLURAL, which indicates more than one.

SPECIFIC refers to the opposite of **GENERIC**.

STAMENS are long thin parts of the inside of a flower that carry pollen.

STRUCTURE is the systematic arrangement of the elements of language, including the ways in which words combine into phrases, phrases into clauses, clauses into sentences, and sentences into larger units of discourse. This process can be compared to constructing a building so structures are often spoken of as constructions. To separate and rearrange the various components of a sentence or some other unit of discourse in the translation process is to **RESTRUCTURE** it.

SUFFIX is a letter or one or more syllables added to the end of a word, to modify the meaning in some manner. For example, “-s” suffixed to “tree” changes the word from singular to plural, “trees,” while “-ing” suffixed to “sing” changes the verb to a participle, “singing.”

SYMBOL (SYMBOLIC) is a form, whether linguistic or nonlinguistic, which is arbitrarily and conventionally associated with a particular meaning. For example, the word “cross” is a linguistic symbol, referring to a particular object. Similarly, within the Christian tradition, the cross as an object is a symbol for the death of Jesus.

SYNONYMS are words that are different in form but similar in meaning, such as “boy” and “lad.” Expressions that have essentially the same meaning are said to be **SYNONYMOUS**. However, no two words are completely synonymous.

SYNTAX is the selection and arrangement of words in phrases, clauses, and sentences.

SYRIAC is the name of a **SEMITIC** language, a part of the **ARAMAIC** family, used in Western Asia, into which the Bible was translated at a very early date (the **Syriac version**).

TARGUM is an Aramaic translation or paraphrase of a section of the ancient Hebrew Scriptures.

TEXT (TEXTUAL) refers to the various Biblical manuscripts. A textual **READING** is the form in which words occur in a particular manuscript (or group of manuscripts), especially where it differs from others. Textual evidence is any evidence from manuscripts that may support a particular reading. **TEXTUAL PROBLEMS** arise when manuscripts contain different readings. These **TEXTUAL VARIATIONS** are readings of the same passage that differ in one or more details. An **EMENDATION** is a scholar’s reconstruction of what the ancient text may have been, even though no manuscript exists today to support that reconstruction. See also MANUSCRIPTS.

TRANSLATION is the transfer of a message in a source language text into another language, the **RECEPTOR LANGUAGE**. A good translation aims at giving the closest natural equivalent in the receptor language in terms of meaning (content and function) and, if possible, also form (style and structure).

TRANSLITERATE (TRANSLITERATION) is to represent in the **RECEPTOR LANGUAGE** the approximate sounds or letters of words occurring in the source language. Transliterating is different from **TRANSLATING**. For example, "Amen" in Hebrew may be transliterated in one language as "amin," or it may be translated as "So be it."

VERBS are a grammatical class of words that express existence, action, state, or occurrence, such as "be," "run," "become," or "think." In some languages ideas expressed by adjectives in English may be better expressed by verbs; for example, "to be hot" or "to be angry."

VOWELS are speech sounds of the vocal cords, produced by unobstructed air passing from the lungs though the mouth. The written letters representing those sounds are also called vowels; for example, "a," "i," or "u," which are the most common vowels found in the world's languages. In Hebrew vowels were originally not written, but they were added later as small marks (called vowel points) written under or above the **CONSONANTS**. See also **CONSONANTS**.

VERSIONS are different translations of the same original document. Among ancient versions of the Bible are the Greek Septuagint, the Syriac, and the Ethiopic. RSV and GNB are modern versions in English.

VULGATE is the Latin version of the Bible translated and/or edited originally by Saint Jerome near the end of the fourth century A.D. It has been traditionally the official version of the Roman Catholic Church.